MAHARASHTRA

POLI PAHILWANS

Maharashtra loves its wrestlers. And why not? Many villages in western Maharashtra have an *akhada* and a fair share of grapplers, and cities like Kolhapur, Pune and Sangli are known for their *talims* (wrestling schools). How could the heaving mud pit of politics be immune to this ? Four grapplers are testing their hold on the popular psyche in the hurly-burly of elections. Two are in Sangli. Chandrahar Patil, a two-time 'Maharashtra Kesari' who learnt from legends like Olympian Ganpatrao Andhalkar, is challenging two-term BJP MP Sanjaykaka Patil on behalf of the Uddhav Sena. His opponent is no pushover, and not just in politics: Sanjaykaka is also a trained wrestler! But the result may hinge on how Congress rebel Vishal Patil, grandson of ex-CM Vasantdada Patil, plays. In Pune, former mayor Murlidhar Mohol of the BJP will be trying all his take-downs, snap-downs and whizzers against Ravindra Dhangekar of the Congress. Originally from the local Mulshi taluka, known for its love of wrestling, Mohol honed his technique in Kolhapur, the state's *kushti pandhari* or 'mecca of wrestling'. Another strongman waiting for the scores with bated breath is ex-Vidarbha Kesari, state wrestling association boss and BJP Wardha MP Ramdas Tadas, running for his political title a third time. They say he may be a bit out of breath against Amar Kale, a soft-spoken ex-Congress MLA chosen this time by Sharad Pawar, a veteran wrestling administrator who headed the state association for four decades till 2022. Now, that's a man who knows a trick or two on the mat.





MUMBAI

A Li'l Shin

He's incisored right between a giant Modi and a smaller **Devendra Fadnavis**, with a diminutive **Ajit Pawar** on the far left, quite the smallest matryoshka doll. So you can't be too sure that **Eknath Shinde** likes his awkward placement. But it's not his relative size in that quartet that matters. The Maharashtra CM probably never imagined he'd live to see a day where his image has more prominence than the two Shiv Sena giants he reveres as his ideological preceptors: **Bal Thackeray** and Shinde's own political mentor and Thane strongman 'Dharmaveer'

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**